The Relationships of the New Man

In Christ every member of the household has equal worth and a God-given place: wives and husbands, children and fathers, servants and masters each serve the Lord Christ with reciprocal duties — equality of worth and order of function, both from the same Lord.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8 **Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae**	**02 1:9–14** **Paul's Prayer for the Colossians**	**03 1:15–23** **The Savior of the Gospel**	**04 1:24–29** **Christ in You, the Hope of Glory**
05 2:1–7 **The Believer's Education**	**06 2:8–15** **Beware of Philosophy**	**07 2:16–23** **Run the Race Set Before You**	**08 3:1–11** **Looking Up, Putting Off**
09 3:12–17 **Service Manual for the Lord's Army**	**10 3:18–4:1** **The Relationships of the New Man**	**11 4:2–6** **Perfecting the Prayer Life**	**12 4:7–18** **Portrait of a Ministry Team**

A household code like no other

Colossians 3:18–4:1 · The commentary's outline

I. Marriage · 3:18–19

Wives: be subject — "as is fitting in the Lord"

Husbands: love — do not be embittered

II. Family · 3:20–21

Children: obey — "well-pleasing to the Lord"

Fathers: do not exasperate — lest they lose heart

III. Business · 3:22–4:1

Servants: obey heartily — "as for the Lord"

Masters: justice and fairness — you too have a Master

Every member addressed directly, the one under authority first, and every person given a duty toward the other.

Submission without inferiority

Colossians 3:18 · Outline I.A — Wives

What they are to do
ὑποτάσσω · a military term

To rank under; arrange oneself in order

To “your” husband — not all men

A recognized, God-given rank in the family

Why — creation order
ἀνήκω · “as is fitting”

A helper suitable (Gen 2:18, 21)

Adam first created, then Eve (1 Tim 2:13)

Not from his head, not from his feet, but from his side (Matthew Henry)

Why — the Godhead
1 Corinthians 11:3

“God is the head of Christ”

The Son is fully equal with the Father, yet submits

So submission does not imply inferiority

Reciprocal duties in marriage and family

Colossians 3:19–21 · Outline I.B and II

Husbands	Love your wives — the self-giving love that seeks her good; not give-and-take affection	**ἀγαπάω** not phileō, not erōs
Husbands	Do not be embittered against them — no nagging or harshness; the same in private as in public	**πικραίνω** to make bitter
Children	Obey your parents in all things — within “in the Lord” (Acts 5:29; Eph 6:1); minor children at home	**ὑπακούω** “to hear under”
Children	“For this is well-pleasing to the Lord” — children want to please, and can learn early to please Him	**εὐάρεστος** fully agreeable
Fathers	Do not exasperate your children — praise well-doing; correct without ceaseless irritation	**ἐρεθίζω** to stir up, provoke
Fathers	“So that they will not lose heart” — discouraged, sullen, even hateful	**ἀθυμέω** disheartened

Work for an audience of One

Colossians 3:22–25 · Outline III.A — Servants

A **Obey earthly masters · v.22**

“According to the flesh” — only Christ is Master of a believer’s spirit

B **Not eye-service · v.22**

ὀφθαλμοδουλία
Not working only when the boss is watching, nor merely pleasing men

C **Heartily, as for the Lord · v.23**

ἐκ ψυχῆς
“From the soul” — wholehearted work; your real Master is in heaven

D **The reward of the inheritance · v.24**

ἀνταπόδοσις · κληρονομία
A full recompense from the Lord Christ — and no partiality (v.25)

Every believer has an inheritance by grace; there is also an inheritance-as-reward for faithful service.

Masters with a Master

Colossians 4:1 · Outline III.B and Conclusion

Treat your workers justly
ἰσότης isotēs · “equality”

Not only what the law required, but what was equitable

God hears withheld wages (Jas 5:4)

Remember your Master in heaven

Every employer is himself an employee of the Lord

He will give an account, in this life and the next

Equality of worth and order of function are not enemies. Both come from the same Lord.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 3:18–4:1 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does 1 Corinthians 11:3 show that submission does not mean inferiority?

2. How should “as for the Lord” (v.23) change the way an employee approaches his work?

Apply

Encourage, Don’t Exasperate
Speak at least one specific word of praise to each child or grandchild in your life every day this week.

Work for an Audience of One
Choose one routine task this week and do it with excellence, consciously offering it to the Lord.

In one line: At home and at work, every relationship is service to the Lord Christ — equal in worth, ordered in function.